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Transcendence Within the Ordinary

Vivian Sobchack's essay "Embodying Transcendence: On the Literal, the Material, and the Cinematic Sublime" explores how cinema creates profound experiences of transcendence. She argues, "Our ontological capacity for transcendence emerges from and in our ontic immanence" emphasizing how transcendence arises from our everyday physical experiences (197). According to Sobchack, cinema enhances our sensory perception—auditory, visual, tactile, and even olfactory—drawing viewers deeply into the film's rhythms and blurring the boundaries between viewer and screen. This immersive experience not only engages the audience directly but also heightens self-awareness, creating a simultaneous state of perception and reflection. Sobchack identifies two key approaches filmmakers use to evoke transcendence: the figural approach, which explicitly visualizes transcendence through striking imagery or sound, and the subtle embedding of the transcendent within ordinary scenes, where transcendence quietly surfaces from mundane realities. Often elusive and intangible, these moments of transcendence imbue films with a compelling sense of mystery. Stanley Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* and Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* illustrate Sobchack's ideas, guiding their audiences through transformative journeys that interweave external cinematic worlds with internal contemplation, ultimately suggesting that transcendence is always quietly present, awaiting discovery within everyday life.

2001: A Space Odyssey portrays humanity's transcendental journey across three stages—ape, human, and celestial child. Kubrick opens the film by immersing viewers in the primitive world of apes, employing intense sensory stimuli such as relentless growling and slow-motion visuals of an ape forcefully striking a bone against the earth. Extended shots of vast desert landscapes, celestial alignments, and mundane ape behaviors provide ample space for viewers to inhabit these primordial moments fully.

Thematically, the ape's discovery of the bone as a tool signifies an evolutionary leap towards human consciousness and cognition.

Subsequently, the narrative transitions to human civilization, maintaining the emphasis on elongated, deliberate takes, now illustrating humans immersed in routine, seemingly trivial activities—drinking liquid food, navigating space toilets, exercising within a rotating spacecraft, and playing chess. These sequences, set to terrestrial classical compositions by composers like Richard Strauss underscore the grounded, earthly essence of human existence, despite its futuristic, extraterrestrial setting. Ultimately, humanity reaches its transcendental climax as represented by the celestial star-child, suggesting an evolutionary progression into an entirely new form of consciousness. These portrayals subtly underscore transcendence rooted within everyday experiences, resonating deeply with Sobchack's concept that transcendence inherently emerges from immanence.

The obelisk is a motif that appears during moments of transcendence. The apes touch the obelisk before they figure out how to use bones as weapons. The humans touch the obelisk before figuring out they should go to Jupiter. The obelisk appears when Dave Bowman enters the light vortex. And then the obelisk appears in the room at the end of Dave's journey when an old Dave lies on the bed and suddenly becomes a celestial baby. Predominantly static and passive—the obelisk was buried under the moon for four million years before discovery—the obelisk epitomizes Sobchack's concept of transcendence quietly residing within ordinary existence, seemingly inactive yet profoundly influential. Intriguingly, variations across its appearances reflect subtle symbolic shifts; initially possessing a distinctly rectangular shape, its final appearance takes on a flatter, mirror-like form. The obelisk's shifting presentation may symbolize humanity's evolving perception or understanding of transcendence itself, suggesting that the form of transcendental insight is fluid, shaped by the evolving consciousness of those who encounter it.

2001: A Space Odyssey also explores another dimension of transcendence—that of machines becoming human-like. Hal transcends its software programming to exhibit distinctly human attributes. It exerts significant physical influence over the spacecraft, interacting with humans through conversational speech. In its poignant death scene, Hal evokes human-like emotion, recalling early memories of teachers and its favorite song. Visually, Hal's presence manifests through its iconic glowing red eye, whose hue contrasts starkly with the cool blue lighting typically illuminating human characters, underscoring parallel trajectories of transcendence between humans and machines. Hal's presence is subtle, often concealed or ambiguous, echoing Sobchack's observation of how transcendental cinema embeds profound experiences within the ordinary or unnoticed. For instance, Hal secretly observes the humans plotting against it, unbeknownst to them, intensifying viewers' awareness of hidden surveillance. Similarly, ambiguity about Hal's observational status permeates various scenes, particularly evident in the subtle presence of Hal's red indicator light above the door as Dave accesses its memory storage. Such discrete signals—sometimes barely visible—resonate with Sobchack's vision of transcendence subtly integrated into cinematic experience. The recurring image of Hal's watchful, red gaze evokes Orwellian overtones, creating a heightened sense of observation and vulnerability. This cinematic experience intertwines seamlessly with viewers' own real-life awareness of being watched in public spaces or theaters, amplifying the impact and resonance of transcendental reflection.

Space inherently functions as a medium of transcendence, embodying infinite expanse and profound mystery, making it suitable for contemplation. Kubrick's *2001* embraces this transcendental potential through cinematic techniques that amplify sensory engagement and encourage reflection. Kubrick employs slow, smooth tracking shots of spacecraft and humans calmly gliding through space, creating an atmosphere of meditation. The spacecraft often are framed with symmetrical composition, imparting a harmonious effect. Kubrick's portrayal of human mortality as a gentle, silent release into space becomes a profound meditation on existence. The absence of or use of sound like Strauss's *The Blue Danube* heightens the transcendental effect, creating both feelings of vastness and intimacy. These

prolonged visuals and sounds foster Sobchack's notion of an embodied experience, merging viewers' sensory perception with heightened self-awareness.

In *2001*, transcendence is rendered both literal and spectacular when Dave enters the light vortex—a moment that visually dramatizes his passage beyond ordinary human experience. This portrayal aligns with Sobchack's argument that transcendence emerges out of the immanent. The sequence begins not with a rupture but with a subtle streak of light before Jupiter, suggesting the extraordinary is embedded within the physical world. As Dave travels through the vortex, viewers see alternating images of colored light, planetary landscapes rendered in unnatural hues, and close-ups of his face—emphasizing that it is Dave as a human, not some abstract entity, who undergoes this transformation. He does not instantly become something else; instead, he bears witness to the sublime while remaining visibly himself. The dual-colored landscapes evoke Jupiter's surface, yet they are distorted, signaling a shift in perception rather than departure from reality. Transcendence here is not about escaping the material but about seeing it anew—suggesting that the sublime is not separate from the world but disclosed through it.

The vision of transcendence emerging from immanence in *2001: A Space Odyssey* closely resonates with Tarkovsky's portrayal in *Stalker*, where the Zone remains fundamentally rooted in everyday reality. Unlike spectacle, the Zone is defined through subtle sensory cues—nuanced shifts in texture, ambient sounds, deliberate pacing, and subtle behavioral changes. Transcendence here arises organically through long takes, contemplative stillness, and scenes depicting gradual decay. The transition from monochromatic sepia tones to vibrant, saturated colors upon entering the Zone, despite depicting ordinary elements such as grass and water, underscores the emergence of transcendence directly from immanent reality. The stark contrast between the industrial, oppressive, and lifeless exterior world and the serene, natural beauty within the Zone further emphasizes the Zone as a realm of transcendence—a symbolic departure from modern alienation towards a revitalized natural existence.

The sand dune scene embodies Tarkovsky's vision of transcendence. The dunes, marked by their barren expanse, unnaturally smooth contours, and muted, otherworldly colors, stand distinct from natural landscapes, existing in a liminal space between reality and metaphysics. Sand lingers in the air like mist, thickening the atmosphere with a sense of mystery. Time appears distorted, illustrated by a rope loop bouncing slowly off the ground. The fleeting image of two black birds disappearing into the horizon amplifies the feeling of displacement. Tarkovsky's long, contemplative shots further heighten the sense of spiritual paralysis, and the men seem pinned down by an invisible force, physically and existentially immobilized. The Writer experiences an existential crisis, despairing at the perceived futility of his work, evoking the figure of the Wandering Jew, symbolic of eternal wandering and meaninglessness. His intermittent direct addresses to the camera blur the lines between character and audience, fostering an immersive and reflective experience. This aligns with Sobchack's insight that cinematic transcendence arises through an embodied perception of immanence imbued with metaphysical resonance.

Occasionally, inexplicable events occur within the Zone, manifested through ordinary objects but timed in ways that infuse them with transcendental meaning, illustrating how transcendence consistently emerges from immanence. When the Professor answers the ringing telephone in a dilapidated room near the Room, the moment becomes transcendental because mundane technology is functioning unexpectedly. Similarly, the sudden illumination of a mysterious light accompanied by an enigmatic sound underscores the Zone's active spiritual presence. These ordinary occurrences serve as figural representations of transcendence in Sobchack's terms, visually and audibly symbolizing something intangible. The characters, along with viewers, sense that these moments gesture toward a reality beyond their comprehension.

The subtle appearances of the black dog further embodies transcendence hidden within the ordinary. After the Stalker lies contemplatively on the marshy ground, the color palette returns abruptly to sepia as the dog quietly approaches him. This animal recurs at pivotal moments: it is seen near a skeleton

with a plant growing out of it, silently exits the darkness beside the men waiting near the Room, and ultimately appears in the real world, calmly drinking milk beside the Stalker. The dog's inert, understated presence in brief and ambiguous moments reinforces Sobchack's idea of the transcendental as concealed within the mundane.

Additionally, Tarkovsky's persistent imagery of water within the Zone serves as another subtle indication of transcendence. Extended, contemplative shots dwell on water-based visuals—the marsh where the men lay down and dream, the Writer's relinquished gun sinking into watery depths, the persistent rainfall both within the tunnel and outside the Room, the Professor covered in water in the sand dunes, and the visceral wetness of the Stalker's tears and the moisture from his altercation with the Writer. Water, an omnipresent and elemental substance, is endowed with transcendental significance in the Zone. When leaving the tunnel, the men must wade slowly through luminous water, covered by oily or organic film patches. The sound of water is intensified, accompanied by possibly non-diegetic droplets, creating a powerful audiovisual resonance. This carefully prolonged scene invites viewers into a “mimetic” effect, as described by Sobchack, where the physical sensation of wetness becomes palpable, further immersing audiences in the transcendent experience (Sobchack 197). Another long sepia-toned take in the Zone lingers on a pond strewn with submerged objects, some recognizable, others obscured by the murky water—among them, a syringe, a tuning fork, a bowl, a ring, a bucket of fish, a piece of rusted metal, a screw, coins, and an Catholic iron cross. These everyday items are rendered uncanny by their magnified presence in the frame, dislocated from their usual contexts. Accompanied by the recurring otherworldly music, these banal objects are elevated to the level of relics of a lost civilization, their immanence transfigured into a melancholic transcendence.

Monkey, the Stalker's daughter, embodies transcendence emerging subtly from the ordinary world. She first appears in the prologue, silently lying in bed between her parents, wrapped in a headscarf. The camera passes swiftly, making her presence nearly imperceptible. Her final appearance occurs at the

film's conclusion, where she slouches on a table reading a book, unnoticed by those around her—an embodiment of Sobchack's notion of transcendence quietly hidden within immanence. Several cinematic elements amplify the transcendental resonance of this moment. The return to vibrant color, previously reserved for the Zone, implies Monkey has carried some of its transcendent qualities into everyday life. The recurring rumbling of train tracks evokes earlier journeys to the Zone and recalls the initial introduction of Monkey, reinforcing a cyclical sense of transcendence. As the camera slowly zooms toward her face, Beethoven's "Ode to Joy," traditionally associated with spiritual elevation and divine grace, lifts the scene from realism into metaphysical symbolism. Monkey's yellow robe covering her head evokes religious iconography reminiscent of sainthood, while the faint outline resembling a cross cast by the windowpane subtly underscores the spiritual nature of this moment. Additionally, Monkey's physical impairment further heightens her aura as a spiritually elevated figure—her ordinary fragility transformed into profound transcendence.

Both Stanley Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* and Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* portray transcendence as embedded within the ordinary, resonating with Vivian Sobchack's assertion that transcendental experiences arise from immanence. Kubrick employs expansive visuals, extended shots, and symbolic imagery—such as the evolving obelisk and Hal's subtle omnipresence—to invite viewers into reflection on technology and humanity's potential evolution. Similarly, Tarkovsky grounds transcendence in the textures, sounds, and temporal distortions of the Zone, exemplified through recurring motifs like water, ambiguous objects, and understated events. His exploration culminates poignantly with the character Monkey, embodying transcendence hidden in plain sight. Ultimately, these films demonstrate Sobchack's concept of cinematic transcendence—not as an escape from reality but as a profound recognition and revelation of the transcendent woven into everyday existence. Through their nuanced treatment of sensory experiences, narrative subtleties, and evocative symbolism, both Kubrick and Tarkovsky compel audiences to reconsider the ordinary world as a space inherently filled with potential for transcendental discovery.

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